unwittingly created what was going to be, in 1947, the pivot for the many-pronged attack on his rule and state. The Poonch family was not the only problem that was going to grow into terrifying proportions.



Image 2.3: Map of Gilgit Agency sharing its boundary with Jammu and Kashmir

Source: Archives of AIM Television Pvt. Ltd.

In 1935, Hari Singh's attitude towards the British had prompted them to take over a 75-year lease on the Gilgit Agency.[23] Gilgit was the last outpost of British India before the landmass of Jammu and Kashmir merged with Sinkiang. To the south of Gilgit flowed the mighty Indus as she meandered westwards towards Punjab. To the north of Gilgit lay the Karakoram Range. Of the eight known passes between Central Asia and the subcontinent, six lay within a week's march from Gilgit. From 1935, the leased region was treated as part of British India and was administered by a Political Agent who reported to the officials in Delhi. As a result, the kingdoms of Chitral, Hunza, Nagar Haveli, Puniyal, Chilas Yasin, Yashkoman and Koh-e-Khizr, all vassals of the Maharaja of Kashmir, now came under direct British rule. The newly leased territory was now called the 'Gilgit Agency'.